The Odious Ogre

By Norton Juster

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

Narrator 1 / Young Girl – Female **Narrator 2 / Ogre – Male**

NARRATOR 1: There was once an Ogre who had a terrible reputation.

NARRATOR 2: Not that Ogres usually have good reputations, but his was worse than anyone could remember – or cared to remember.

NARRATOR 1: He was, it was widely believed, extraordinarily large, exceedingly ugly, unusually angry, constantly hungry, and absolutely merciless.

NARRATOR 2: Nobody, however, could claim to know anything about him for sure. To tell the truth, there wasn't anyone to be found who had actually made his acquaintance and was still around to talk about it.

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *Fe, Fi, Fo, Fum . . . I smell the blood of an Englishman.*
ACTOR 2: *That's not an OGRE, that's the Giant from Jack and the Beanstalk.*
ACTOR 1: *(In your best SHRECK VOICE) Oh, yeah, yeah . . . this one is about an ORGRE who, in order to regain his swamp, travels along with a donkey in order to bring a princess to a scheming lord who wishes to become King.*
Actor 2: *No . . . That's SHREK – Right species . . different story. This is the story of*
TOGETHER: *The Odious Ogre by Norton Juster*

NARRATOR 1: Now, the one thing everyone did know for sure was that they could not

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think of anything to do about him.

TOWNFOLK 1: It's hopeless!

TOWNFOLK 2: If we try to do anything it will only make things worse!

TOWNFOLK 3: Maybe if we're nice he'll only eat some of us.

NARRATOR 1: As you can imagine, no Ogre ever had it so good.

NARRATOR 2: Every time there was even a hint that he was in the neighborhood, people stuffed their ears with stale cake, blindfolded themselves, clutched their knees, and rolled up in a ball under the kitchen table.

NARRATOR 2: Since this is not the most effective defensive posture, the Ogre would wander through the town, making a leisurely buffet of the local population.

NARRATOR 1: For the Ogre, it was quite a relaxing life and, as happens, he grew a bit lazy and self-satisfied, maybe even smug, and definitely spoiled. Everything came so easily for him. He grew to expect it –

ODIUS OGRE: No one can resist me. I am invulnerable, impregnable, insuperable, indefatigable, insurmountable.

NARRATOR 1: He let each satisfying word roll smoothly off his tongue. The Ogre did have quite an impressive vocabulary, due mainly to having inadvertently swallowed a large dictionary while consuming the head librarian in one of the nearby towns.

ODIUS OGRE: What can they do? No one can resist me

NARRATOR 1: That's the way it was for him. No doubts, no concerns, no worries.

ODIUS OGRE: I am invincible – Absolutely invincible!

NARRATOR 1: One afternoon, as he ambled down the road towards one of the nearby villages in search of dinner, he saw a small cottage way off in the distance that he had not noticed before.

ODIUS OGRE: Maybe I'll stop for a little snack first

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NARRATOR: He lurched down the long narrow track to see what tasty tidbit he might find.

NARRATOR 2: The cottage was deep in the woods, far removed from the busy goings-on of the world, and unknown to the Ogre, his reputation had NOT preceded him.

NARRATOR 1: He paused at the edge of the trees. The cottage was quite pretty. Even the Ogre, who didn't care much for pretty (it doesn't taste any better than ugly) was impressed.

NARRATOR 2: Outside the cottage a young girl worked busily in the garden.

ODIUS OGRE: (Sneaks up on young girl – Stomps feet, Roars, Licks his lips).

NARRATOR 2: The trees swayed to the ground. The birds flew off in great confusion and even the cottage seemed to shudder.

YOUNG GIRL: Oh, pardon me. I didn't realize anyone was there. I'll be right with you.

ODIUS OGRE: (Looks startled, mouth drops open, hand begin to shake) - [To himself/audience] What's going on! Why didn't she just shrivel up and collapse? How dare she treat me this way?

YOUNG GIRL: (Pauses from her work, looks up, smiles) What a nice strong voice you have. But do forgive my bad manners. Please sit down and have a cup of tea. We get so few visitors these days.

ODIUS OGRE: But how can you be so calm? Don't you know how terrible I am? Haven't you heard about me? Where have you been, for goodness' sake?

YOUNG GIRL: Oh, you're not really so terrible. Overbearing perhaps, arrogant for sure, somewhat self-important, a little too mean and violent, I'm afraid, and a bit missy. But I'll bet if you brushed your teeth, combed your hair, found some new clothes, and totally changed your attitude you'd be quite nice.

NARRATOR 1: The ogre was now in real distress. His head felt all funny, He just didn't

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understand what was happening. This was not the docile dumpling he had expected.

ODIUS OGRE: (To himself/audience) She hasn't even heard of me. And not only isn't she afraid of me, I think she likes me! I can't be liked. It's bad for business."

YOUNG GIRL: One lump or two? It's so nice of yu to drop by. Are you new to the neighborhood?

ODIUS OGRE: NEW! I'm the scourge of the countryside. Your worst nightmare! This is humiliating, so depressing, so unfair, so embarrassing. (Looking around nervously) (Young girl smiles patiently) Maybe it's a trap. It must be a trap. YES, IT'S A TRAP! She probably has everyone hiding in the bushes, waiting to swoop down on me. Look at her! She's so confident. If I pounce, she probably knows all kinds of secret, painful ways to stop me. What can I do? How can I live if I can't ravage and plunder? (To the young girl) I think I should be leaving . . .

YOUNG GIRL: Oh, please don't leave before you've had a muffin. I baked them myself this morning. They're still warm.

ODIUS OGRE: A muffin! I don't want a muffin. Muffins are nice, but couldn't I have surrender?

NARRATOR 1: For the briefest of moments, his thoughts flashed back to delicious memories from his reprehensible life.

ODIUS OGRE: (Re-enact ravaging and plundering)

NARRATOR 1: But only for a moment, for his problem still stood facing him, generously offering her muffins,

ODIUS OGRE: This is not the way it's supposed to be.

NARRATOR 2: He was sure of that, but what to do? Then suddenly he thought he knew.

NARRATOR 1: In a last desperate attempt to reassert his fearsome presence, he drew

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himself up to his most menacing height, his eyes slits of determination. He leaped up and hurled himself around the garden – bellowing, stomping, blustering, grimacing, twitching, snorting, belching, clawing, and drooling. When he finished, he stood back exhausted, awaiting her abject surrender.

NARRATOR 2: The girl was overwhelmed. She took a ddep breath, put the muffins down carefully and . . .

YOUNG GIRL: (Applauds) What fun, how magical, how wonderful! Would you consider doing that for the orphans' picnic next week? I know the children would love it.

NARRATOR 1: The Ogre was stunned. Despair reached to the depths of his shallow soul.

ODIUS OGRE: It's no use, I'm confounded, overcome, and undone.

NARRATOR 1: He turned and, without a word, began to walk back towards the trees, the scent of the warm muffins still lingering in the air. He had taken only a few steps when he stopped, stood perfectly still for several long seconds, then stumbled back . . . keeled over, and expired on the spot, a look of uncomprehending disbelief covering his anguished face.

NARRATOR 2: When the townspeople heard the news, they all arrived to celebrate and to buy him. But most of them would not dare look at him, since reputations, of course, die harder than Ogres.

NARRATOR 1: As you might expect, some of the less gracious among them wree reluctant to give the girl any credit at all.

TOWNSFOLK 1: He wasn't that terrible. Anyone could have done it.

TOWNSFOLK 2: She must have had a lot of help.

TOWNSFOLK 3: I could have dealt with him myself, but I've been busy.

NARRATOR 2: None of that mattered to the girl. It wasn't even clear to her what all

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the fuss was about. She had simply treated the Ogre as she treated every9one else, with kindness, generosity, and understanding.

NARRATOR 1: This was just too frightening for the Ogre to bear.

NARRATOR 2: She also understood that the terrible things that can happened when you come face-to-face with an Ogre can sometimes happen to the Ogre and not to you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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